



LIONS LIGHT ACADEMY

Setting Up Your Google Classroom

A three-minute job for leadership, and the rest is yours

"It is the glory of God to conceal a matter, but the glory of kings is to search it out."

PROVERBS 25:2

Version 1.3 supersedes v1.2. Moves getting the app to the front, before accepting the invitation — it was buried on page 7, which is after the point most teachers go looking for their class.

Version 1.2 supersedes v1.1. Adds what a student needs in order to join at all (a Google Account, and why most Elementary students should not have their own), plus how to get back into your class and how to make a one-tap shortcut.

How this is split. Leadership creates the empty class and hands you the keys. **Everything inside it is yours** — topics, materials, assignments, students, grading. That's deliberate. You know your subject and we don't.

Part One is for leadership and takes about three minutes per class. Part Two is for teachers and takes about half an hour once, then a few minutes a week.

PART ONE • Leadership

Do this once per class, before the teacher starts. Roughly three minutes.

Why leadership creates the class, not the teacher

The person who creates a Google Classroom **owns** it. If a teacher creates their own class and then steps away mid-year — moves, has a baby, life happens — LLA cannot get into it, cannot recover the students' work, and the link on our website goes dead.

So leadership creates the shell and adds the teacher as a **co-teacher**. A co-teacher can do everything that matters: post, assign, grade, add students, change the theme. The only things they can't do are delete the class or remove the owner. That's exactly the line we want.

The five steps

1. Go to **classroom.google.com** and click + → **Create class**
2. Fill in the fields using our naming convention, so classes stay findable year over year:

FIELD	WHAT TO ENTER	EXAMPLE
Class name	LLA <Subject> – <Age Group>	LLA Art – Elementary
Section	The school year	2026–2027
Subject	The subject	Art
Room	Leave blank	

3. Open **People** → **Invite teachers** (the person-plus icon next to Teachers). Enter the teacher's email and click **Invite**. A personal Gmail address is fine.
4. Open **Settings** (the gear icon) and copy two things into your records: - The **class code** — the teacher gives this to students - The **class link** — this goes on the website
5. Send the teacher the class link, the class code, and this guide. **Tell them the invitation only exists in their email** — nothing appears inside Classroom until they accept it, and a teacher who goes looking there will find an empty page and assume you forgot them.

That's it. Do not build topics, post materials, or add students. That's the teacher's job and they'll do it better than you.

Adding it to the website

Send the class link to whoever maintains the site. The Classes section groups links by Elementary, Middle School, and High School, so say which band it belongs to.

One limitation worth knowing

LLA runs on personal Google accounts rather than a Google Workspace for Education domain. Two consequences:

- **Students 13 and under should not have their own account.** Google's policy is that children aged 13 and under should only use Classroom with a Workspace for Education account. For Elementary, the parent joins with the class code instead — tell families that up front
- **Guardian summaries are unavailable.** Google's automatic parent digest emails only work on Workspace for Education accounts. Parents see their student's work by asking their student, or by the teacher posting to the class. Don't promise families a digest that can't be sent.
- Personal accounts cap at **250 members per class** and **100 invitations per day**. Nowhere near a constraint at our size, but it's the ceiling.

If LLA ever incorporates and qualifies for Google Workspace for Education, guardian summaries become available and it would be worth revisiting.

PART TWO • Teachers

Everything from here is yours. Budget about thirty minutes the first time.

Before you start — get the app

Do this first, on your phone, before anything else. The rest of this guide works on a laptop, but the app is where you'll actually live once the year is running — checking who turned in what between Tuesdays takes seconds on a phone and is a chore on a desktop.

- **iPhone or iPad** — App Store, search **Google Classroom**
- **Android** — Google Play, search **Google Classroom**

Publisher is Google LLC. There are lookalikes.

Sign in as the account leadership sent your invitation to. If you have more than one Google account on your phone — most people do — the app will happily open the wrong one and show you nothing. Tap the profile picture top right and check before you assume something is broken.

There's a comparison of what's better on a phone and what's better on a desktop later in this guide. You don't need it yet. Just get the app on before you go looking for your class.

Step 1 • Accept the invitation

Go to your email. Open the invitation from Google Classroom and click **Accept invite**.

Do not go looking for it inside Classroom. Co-teacher invitations never appear there — no card, no banner, no pending notice. Until you accept from the email, classroom.google.com shows an empty page reading *"Add a class to get started,"* exactly as though nothing had been sent. That is normal. It is also the single most common reason a teacher concludes they were skipped.

Can't find the email? Check spam first, then ask leadership to re-send. Invitations expire.

Once you accept, you are a **co-teacher**. You can do everything except delete the class — which is a feature, not a limitation. You cannot accidentally destroy a term's work.

Step 2 • Make it yours

Click **Customize** on the class banner. Pick a theme or upload a photo relevant to your subject.

This takes ten seconds and it matters more than it sounds. Students land in a page that looks like *your* class rather than a generic grey template.

Step 3 • Write the class description

Settings (gear icon) → **Class description**. Three or four sentences:

- What this class is about
- What students will actually do in it
- What you expect them to bring or prepare each week

Example: "We're reading the world as God wrote it — rocks, weather, water, and the systems that tie them together. Expect to be outside some weeks. Bring a notebook you don't mind getting muddy. Read the assigned pages before Tuesday so we can spend class doing rather than catching up."

Step 4 • Build your Topics

Classwork → **Create** → **Topic**.

Topics are your units, and they're what keeps a class from turning into an undifferentiated scroll by November. Make them before you post anything.

Most teachers want something like: - **Course Information** - One topic per unit — **Unit 1 – Foundations**, **Unit 2 – ...** - **Reference & Resources**

Every single thing you post afterward gets filed under a topic. No exceptions, or the scroll wins.

Step 5 • Post your course outline

Classwork → **Create** → **Material** → file it under **Course Information**.

Include your units, roughly when each lands, and what students need for the class. It doesn't have to be polished. It has to exist, because it's the thing a parent looks for in week three when they're trying to support their student.

Step 6 • Create your first assignment

Classwork → Create → Assignment.

- **Title** — specific. "Chapter 4 questions," not "Homework"
- **Instructions** — what to do, and what done looks like
- **Due date** — **set it to the Monday before class**, not the Tuesday

That last point is the whole game. Our policy treats work not done for two Tuesdays running as a moderate concern, and that only works if the deadline lands before class rather than during it. A Monday due date means you walk in knowing who's ready.

Step 7 • Get your students in

Do not chase down email addresses. Use the class code.

Your class code is on the Settings page and in the header of your Stream. Hand it out on the first day, and put it in the LLA Google Chat space.

Students go to **classroom.google.com** → + → **Join class** → type the code.

Five minutes of class time on day one, and you're done. This is much faster than collecting and typing twenty email addresses.

The code is not enough on its own

A student must be signed into a Google Account before the code will work. The code is the address, not the key. Someone who types it while signed out gets nowhere.

It does **not** have to be a Gmail address. On Google's signup screen there is an option reading **"Use your existing email"** — a family can turn an address they already have into a Google Account without creating a Gmail inbox.

Elementary: the parent joins, not the student

Google's own policy is that **children aged 13 and under should only use Classroom with a Workspace for Education account.** LLA runs on personal Google accounts, and our entire Elementary group is under 13.

So for Elementary, and for the younger half of Middle School, **the parent is the account.** Give the code to the parent. They join on their own device and see everything the student would.

This is the normal path, not a workaround. Say so to families plainly, or they will try to create an account for an eight-year-old and hit an age wall.

The parent appears on your roster under **their own name**, not the student's. Note who is who before you start grading, or you will be looking for a child who isn't on the list.

Step 8 • Get back in without hunting for it

`classroom.google.com` , signed into the account that accepted the invitation. That is the whole answer, with one trap in front of it.

If you are signed into more than one Google account, Classroom opens the wrong one. It loads whichever account is your *default*, and your class will not be there — you will get an empty page reading "Add a class to get started," which looks exactly like the not-accepted-yet problem. Your class actually lives at `classroom.google.com/u/1/` or `/u/2/` , depending on the order you signed in.

The fix is to bookmark your class, not Classroom. A class link looks like `classroom.google.com/c/0DE5MzE4NTUyMzEw` . It carries the right account with it, so the multiple-account problem disappears. Leadership sends you this link; keep it.

Make it one tap

WHERE	HOW
Phone — best	Install the Google Classroom app from the App Store or Play Store. Handles multiple accounts properly and notifies you when work is turned in
Phone — no app	Open your class in Safari or Chrome → Share → Add to Home Screen
Desktop Chrome	Open your class → three-dot menu → Cast, save and share → Install page as app . It gets its own dock or taskbar icon
Anywhere	Bookmark the class link itself. Simplest thing that works

Step 9 • Set your weekly rhythm

Pick a day and keep it. Most teachers land on:

- **Friday or Saturday** — post next week's assignment, due Monday

- **Monday evening** — glance at who submitted. That's your two-session count
- **Tuesday after class** — post anything referenced in class; return graded work

Twenty minutes a week once the class is running.

The Two-Session Rule, in Classroom terms

Our Escalation & Discipline Policy: **required work not completed for two class sessions in a row is a moderate concern**, and you raise it to leadership.

Classroom makes this easy to see rather than remember. Open **Classwork** → your assignment → and the **Assigned / Turned in / Graded** counts are right there.

If the same student shows as missing two Tuesdays running, that's your trigger. Report it — leadership issues the warning and contacts the family. You don't have to track counts across the co-op; that's leadership's job.

One thing worth doing before you report: **check whether they submitted something and you missed it**. Classroom sometimes puts late work below the fold.

Things not to do

Don't delete the class. You can't, and that's on purpose.

Don't remove Damian as owner. Same.

Don't post grades or comments about a student where the class can see them. Use **private comments** on the individual assignment.

Don't rename the class away from the convention. The website links to it and other people need to find it.

Don't create a second class for the same subject. If something's wrong with the one you have, ask leadership to fix it.

When something goes wrong

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
Classroom is empty, "Add a class to get started"	You haven't accepted yet. The invitation is in your email, not in Classroom. Accept it there
Empty page, but you <i>did</i> accept	You are on the wrong Google account. Try <code>classroom.google.com/u/1/</code> , then <code>/u/2/</code> . Then bookmark the class link so it never happens again
Student typed the code and it did nothing	They were not signed into a Google Account. The code alone does not work
Student is under 13 and cannot make an account	Correct, and expected. The parent joins with the code instead
Never got the invitation	Check spam. Then ask leadership to re-send — invitations expire
Student can't join with the code	Codes are case-insensitive but easy to mis-read. Zero and O, one and I. Read it out slowly, or paste it into Chat
Wrong class name or section	Ask leadership. Renaming breaks the website link
Student in the wrong class	Leadership moves them. Don't remove a student yourself
Assignment posted to the wrong topic	Open it, click the three dots, Edit , change the topic
Need to reuse last year's material	Classwork → Reuse post → pick the old class. Saves rebuilding a whole unit

The short version

Leadership: create the class, invite the teacher as co-teacher, send the link and code. Three minutes. Nothing else.

Teachers:

1. Accept the invitation **from the email** — it is not in Classroom

2. Customize the banner
3. Write the class description
4. Build your Topics first
5. Post your course outline
6. First assignment, **due Monday**
7. Hand out the class code on day one. Elementary: give it to the **parent**
8. Bookmark your class link, not classroom.google.com
9. Post weekly, check submissions Monday night